

Coherence

When sentences, ideas, and details fit together clearly, readers can follow along easily, and the writing is coherent. The ideas tie together smoothly and clearly. To establish the links that readers need, you can use the methods listed here. Note that good writers use a combination of these methods. Do not rely on and overuse any single method – especially transitional words.

Repetition of a Key Term or Phrase

This helps to focus your ideas and to keep your reader on track.

Example:

The problem with **contemporary art** is that it is not easily understood by most people. **Contemporary art** is deliberately abstract, and that means it leaves the viewer wondering what she is looking at.

Synonyms

Synonyms are words that have essentially the same meaning, and they provide some variety in your word choices, helping the reader to stay focused on the idea being discussed.

Example:

Myths narrate sacred histories and explain sacred origins. These **traditional narratives** are, in short, a set of beliefs that are a very real force in the lives of the people who tell them.

Pronouns

This, that, these, those, he, she, it, they, and we are useful pronouns for referring back to something previously mentioned. Be sure, however, that what you are referring to is clear.

Example:

When **scientific experiments** do not work out as expected, **they** are often considered failures until some other scientist tries them again. Those that work out better the second time around are the ones that promise the most rewards.

Transitional Words

There are many words in English that cue our readers to relationships between sentences, joining sentences together. See below for a table of transitional words. There you'll find lists of words such as *however, therefore,*

in addition, also, but, moreover, etc.

Example:

I like autumn, **and yet** autumn is a sad time of the year, too. The leaves turn bright shades of red and the weather is mild, **but** I can't help thinking ahead to the winter and the ice storms that will surely blow through here. **In addition**, that will be the season of chapped faces, too many layers of clothes to put on, and days when I'll have to shovel heaps of snow from my car's windshield.

Note that transitional words have meaning and are not just used at beginnings of sentences. They can also be used to show relationships between different parts of the same sentence. As mentioned above they cue readers to relationships between sentences/clauses. If you use the wrong transitional word then you confuse your reader. It would be better if you didn't use any transitional word rather than the wrong one. Furthermore you do not need a transitional word at the beginning of each sentence. Good writers rarely use them as they achieve coherence by using other techniques. Many students overuse transitional words. Your instructor will guide you as to what problems you may have with transitions.

Sentence Patterns

Sometimes, repeated or parallel sentence patterns can help the reader follow along and keep ideas tied together.

Example: (from a speech by President John F. Kennedy)

And so, my fellow Americans: ask not what your country can do for you--ask what you can do for your country.

Much of the above information was obtained from Purdue University. Details below.
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Transitional Words

Addition

[again](#)

[also](#)

[and](#)

[and then](#)

[besides](#)

[equally](#)

[further\(more\)](#)

[in addition](#) (to...)

[indeed](#)

[next](#)

[in fact](#)

[moreover](#)

[too](#)

[what is more](#)

[finally](#)

Comparison		
compared with in comparison with in the same way/manner	similarly likewise	again also
Contrast		
besides but however in contrast instead conversely it may be the case that certainly also likewise	naturally nevertheless of course on the contrary on the other hand regardless granted like different from Alternatively	still whereas while yet although despite it is true that notwithstanding
Enumeration		
first(ly) secondly etc. finally in the (first) place	last to (begin) with more important	on top of (that) next then
Concession		
although it is true that it may appear regardless certainly	granted that naturally it is true that I admit that	of course it may be the case that
Exemplification		
as (evidence of...) for example for instance thus to illustrate	such as to show what (I mean) specifically let us (take the case of...)	
Inference		
if not, ... in (that) case	otherwise that implies	then
Summary/Conclusion		
in all in brief to summarise in summary	in short in conclusion therefore In a nutshell	on the whole to sum up basically

Time and Sequence

after (a while) afterwards at first at last at (the same time) while first , second, third... thereafter concurrently soon as soon as	before (that time) finally in the end meanwhile next immediately next firstly , secondly, thirdly... in the future subsequently at that time	since (then) so far then (up to) (then) later somewhat earlier shortly over the next (2 days) as long as last
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Result

accordingly as a result consequently since as a consequence of... caused accordingly	for that reason hence thus if...then... ... result(s) in ... contribute to In consequence	then therefore the (consequence) of that is... ... is due to... brought about by/because... lead to...
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Reformulation

in other words rather Briefly put simply	that is (to say) to put it more (simply) basically
---	--

Replacement

again alternatively	(better) still on the other hand	the alternative is...
--	---	--

Transition

as far as ... is concerned as for ... incidentally	now to turn to... with (reference) to	with regard to... Concerning...
--	---	--

Place/Position

above beyond in the back nearby elsewhere	adjacent here near there far to the left	below in front there closer to farther on to the right
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opposite to behind		
Miscellaneous - Adverbs may be used at the beginning of sentences to show how the sentence which follows relates to the rest of the text. Many of them reveal the writers attitude to the idea they are expressing and so can be used as an important tool in evaluative writing.		
Admittedly All things considered As a general rule As far as we know Astonishingly Broadly By and large Characteristically Clearly Coincidentally Conveniently Curiously Disappointingly Equally Essentially Explicitly Even so Eventually Fortunately	Fundamentally Generally speaking Interestingly Ironically In essence In general In particular In practice In reality In retrospect/hindsight In theory In view of this More interestingly More seriously More specifically Naturally On balance Obviously On reflection Overall	Paradoxically Potentially Predictably Presumably Primarily Probably Remarkably Seemingly Significantly Surprisingly Theoretically To all intents and purposes Typically Ultimately Understandably Undoubtedly Unfortunately With hindsight

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